them . . . they killed the clergy too, and the women and the children. . . . So terrible a slaughter has not been known or consented to, I think, since the time of the Saracens." The city burned, with many of the survivors trapped inside the flames. It was July 22, 1209.[13]



33.1 The Albigensian Crusade

The Crusaders then marched on towards the city of Carcassonne, arriving there on August 1 and laying siege to the walls. Carcassonne was already overstuffed with refugees who had fled into it in front of the advancing army. After just two weeks, the populace surrendered.

After Carcassonne, the Abbot of Cisteaux expressed a wish to go back to his monastery. So the Crusaders elected a new leader: Simon de Montfort, who had distinguished himself in the fighting. Innocent III confirmed the election by declaring Montfort not only general of the Crusaders but also ruler of all lands "conquered or to be conquered" during the Crusade.

Simon de Montfort, now aged forty-nine, was at loose ends after losing his lands to King John. He was "a tough fighting man," writes his contemporary William of Tudela; tall, broad-shouldered, and handsome, says the French chronicler Pierre des Vaux de Cernay, "extremely experienced in warfare, tireless . . . and totally dedicated to the service of God." Montfort had